

thinly populated Phuoc Long was initially defended only by South Vietnamese Regional and Popular Forces. Even when these militia were hastily reinforced by an ARVN infantry battalion, helicoptered in from their base at Lai Khe, North Vietnam's superiority in numbers and firepower was overwhelming. The US reaction, meanwhile, was underwhelming. The Third Marine Division in Okinawa was put on alert and the USS *Enterprise* was sent closer to Vietnam, but no other action was taken.

The fighting in Phuoc Long began on 12 December. The provincial capital of Phuoc Binh—also known as Phuoc Long City—was quickly isolated, its defenders dependent on aerial resupply. Heavy anti-aircraft fire deterred ARVN pilots from flying low enough to achieve accurate airdrops or provide effective close air support to ground troops.

North Vietnamese (NVA) artillery were pouring 3,000 rounds a day into Phuoc Binh by early January. Two companies of elite Airborne Rangers were flown in as the situation worsened for the ARVN, but this was no more than a sacrificial gesture. On January 6, Phuoc Binh fell. It was the first provincial capital lost by the South Vietnamese government since Quang Tri at Easter 1972.